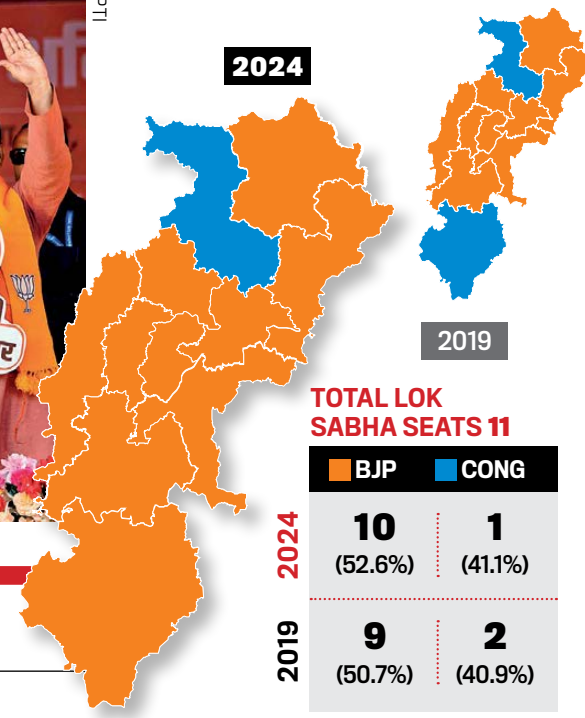


PTI

STEADY SHOW
Amit Shah with CM Vishnu Deo Sai in Khairagarh in April



TOTAL LOK SABHA SEATS 11

	BJP	CONG
2024	10 (52.6%)	1 (41.1%)
2019	9 (50.7%)	2 (40.9%)

Vote share in ( )

| CHHATTISGARH |

BJP RULES THE ROOST

The saffron perch in the state seems secure for mow, but not for ever should it drop its guard

By **Rahul Noronha**

To someone not from the state, the results of the past three Lok Sabha elections in Chhattisgarh would suggest a political placidity. The BJP won 10 of the 11 Lok Sabha seats in the state in 2014, lost one to the Congress in 2019 to reach a tally of nine (against the Congress's two), and reclaimed it again this year for a score of 10, to the Congress's one. The difference in vote share between the two principal challengers has also remained more or less the same in the past decade, around 10 per cent. For political observers on the ground though, the just-concluded election presents a nuanced design.

Chhattisgarh was one of the three states where the BJP won assembly elections held in November last year. Despite that, the Congress went to the Lok Sabha election on a positive note. The reason? The party had in the 2018 assembly polls won 68 of the state's 90 assembly seats, unseating the BJP in Chhattisgarh after one and a half decades. However, in the Lok Sabha polls that followed in 2019, the BJP won nine of the 11 LS seats. This year, too, the state seemed set for a close contest, and especially in seats like Bastar, Kanker, Rajnandgaon, Janjgir-Champa and Korba, political observers believed the Congress to be a strong contender. So what helped the BJP check the Congress's charge? "The BJP gained in tribal areas [like Bastar, Raigarh and Kanker] after it appointed Vishnu Deo Sai as the state's first tribal CM," says political analyst Sudeep Shrivastava.

While Prime Minister Narendra Modi's popularity continued to work in favour of the BJP, the Sai-led state government also delivered on promises made ahead of the assembly polls, such as financial assistance to eligible women under the Mahtari Vandan Yojana and procuring paddy at Rs 3,100 per quintal from farmers. A third factor that boosted the BJP's chances was the 'outsider' tag that many of the Congress candidates were fighting. Former CM Bhupesh Baghel is not from Rajnandgaon, the seat from where he was fielded. Nor were former state home minister Tamradhwaj Sahu from the Mahasamund constituency, former minister Shiv Kumar Dahariya, a Janjgir-Champa local, or MLA Devendra Yadav a native of the Bilaspur seat from where he contested. All of them lost to local BJP candidates.

Interestingly, that very factor worked for the Congress in the lone seat that it won in the state, Korba. Despite perceived anti-incumbency against sitting Congress MP Jyotsna Mahant, she managed to retain the seat. "Charandas Mahant [leader of opposition in Chhattisgarh and Jyotsna's husband] turned the campaign into an insider vs outsider one [BJP candidate Saroj Pandey was not only not from Korba, but her family does not have roots in Chhattisgarh]," says a BJP leader.

The loss of a single seat to its rival may seem to be a matter of little concern to the BJP, but political analysts feel the party should guard against complacency in Chhattisgarh. The Congress does have 35 MLAs in the 90-member state assembly, and an upcoming byelection in Raipur South, to fill the seat vacated by Brijmohan Agarwal following his election as Raipur MP, would be a test of strength for the Sai government. ■